

Cardinal Flower

Lobelia cardinalis

Red Lobelia



QUALITIES

An upright wetland perennial 2 to 4 feet tall, with narrow lance-shaped leaves and a vertical spike of vivid scarlet two-lipped flowers from August into September. The red is so saturated it is almost shocking against late-summer prairie greens — the single most striking flower color in the Minnesota native flora. Short-lived (3-5 year) but reliably self-seeds in suitable conditions.

CARE

Moist to wet soil; the wetter the better. Full sun to part shade. Hardy to USDA Zone 3. Plant from 1-gallon stock in spring or fall; do not let the root ball dry out during establishment. Mulch lightly in fall to protect the basal rosette through winter. Allow self-seeding in compatible spots; replace as the original parent plants decline. Deer-resistant.

HISTORY

Named for its resemblance to a Cardinal's red robe, the plant has been cultivated since the 1620s. Indigenous peoples used the root for love medicine and for respiratory illness, though the alkaloids are toxic and the plant requires careful handling. Cardinal Flower appears in Audubon's earliest American botanical watercolors (1820s) — it has long been recognized as one of the most beautiful native plants of eastern North America.

REASON TO BE

Cardinal flower is *the* hummingbird plant. The Ruby-throated Hummingbird is its primary pollinator — the narrow tubular red flower is an evolutionary co-adaptation. In late August and September, when hummingbirds are migrating south and need high-energy nectar, a stand of cardinal flower is a refueling station. The vivid red also draws Eastern Tiger and Spicebush Swallowtails. In a vegetated bioswale, cardinal flower transforms the moist slope from "green stormwater function" to "emotional anchor."